

THE SELF FROM VARIOUS PERSPECTIVES

Introduction

- Exploring the self through philosophical perspectives to uncover insights about identity and human nature.

THE SELF FROM PHILOSOPHICAL PERSPECTIVES

Socrates

- **Core Philosophy:** Ancient Greek philosopher who emphasized self-knowledge through the maxim, "Know thyself." Believed true wisdom comes from introspection and self-examination. Acknowledging ignorance improves receptivity to new perspectives, situational adaptation, and personal development. Socratic dialogues such as *The Apology* and *The Phaedrus* illustrate his teachings.
- **Example:** Maria is unsure about her career path. She reflects on her loves and values, as Socrates suggested, and chooses a career matching her interests rather than succumbing to pressure to pick a well-paying job she dislikes. This demonstrates knowing oneself and living true to who one is.

Plato

- **Core Philosophy:** Ancient Greek philosopher who argued that the self is immortal and independent of the body, with the highest knowledge derived from contemplating the Form of the Good. Proposed the tripartite theory of the soul, stating the self comprises three parts: reason, spirit, and appetite. Harmony among these parts leads to a virtuous life and a just society.
- **Example:** Jack is torn between studying for an exam or playing video games. His mind urges him to study, while his desires push him to play. He listens to his mind and chooses to study, illustrating Plato's idea of balancing desire-driven parts with the winning rational part of the soul.

Aristotle

- **Core Philosophy:** Ancient Greek philosopher, polymath, and student of Plato for twenty years who rejected Plato's Theory of Forms. Formulated the concept of self through *hylomorphism*, arguing that the self/human person is an inseparable composite of body and soul. The self is viewed as a unified creature that cannot be discussed as soul-only or body-only.
- **Example:** Toby loves dancing. When he dances, his physical movements express not just his skills (body) but also his emotions and passion (soul), illustrating how the body and soul work together as an inseparable unit to convey inner feelings and creativity.

Saint Augustine

- **Core Philosophy:** Augustine of Hippo was a theologian and philosopher who viewed the self as deeply intertwined with God, believing the human soul longs for union with

God as its ultimate source of fulfillment and happiness. Grounded the self in original sin inherited from Adam and Eve, which leads to spiritual longing and discontent, resolved through God's grace.

- **Example:** Emma struggles between telling the truth or keeping a secret. After reflecting on her values, she chooses honesty. This reflects Augustine's view that inner conflict between selfish desires and moral convictions shapes character and choices.

René Descartes

- **Core Philosophy:** French philosopher, scientist, and mathematician who proposed dualism, separating the self into distinct entities: mind and body. Coined "Cogito, ergo sum" (I think, therefore I am), asserting self-awareness proves existence. Associated the mind with consciousness and the body with mechanical processes, locating the self in the mind.
- **Example:** Unsure if surroundings are real, a person realizes that the very act of thinking about it proves they exist. This illustrates Descartes' principle that the ability to think proves one is a real person with thoughts and awareness.

John Locke

- **Core Philosophy:** English philosopher and physician who proposed a theory of the self based on consciousness and personal identity. Posited that people begin life as a *Tabula rasa* (blank slate) and that the self is shaped by life experiences. Argued that personal identity remains continuous as long as one remembers being oneself across different times.
- **Example:** David reflects on childhood memories and favorite activities to see how those experiences shaped his present identity. This illustrates Locke's concept of self as a continuous stream of consciousness linked by memories.

David Hume

- **Core Philosophy:** Scottish Enlightenment philosopher, historian, economist, librarian, and essayist who rejected the notion of a fixed, enduring self. Proposed the *Bundle Theory*, arguing the self is merely a bundle of perceptions, thoughts, and sensations. The sense of self is an illusion created by the mind from the flow of evolving experiences.
- **Example:** Barbara enjoys various hobbies and changes her opinions as she grows older. According to Hume, there is no single, unchangeable self behind these changes; identity evolves continuously through shifting experiences and feelings.

Immanuel Kant

- **Core Philosophy:** German philosopher and central Enlightenment thinker whose concept of self revolves around the inner self (transcendental self) and the outer self (empirical self). The inner self encompasses emotions and rational intellect ("I think"). The outer self consists of the physical body and interactions with the physical world perceived by others.

- **Example:** While learning piano, the inner self (conscious thinking subject) guides the learning process and self-awareness, while the outer self includes the physical body sitting at the piano, moving across the keys, and producing observable sounds.

Sigmund Freud

- **Core Philosophy:** Austrian neurologist and founder of psychoanalysis whose concept of self focused on the *ego* within the psychoanalytic theory of the psyche. The ego serves as a mediator between the *id* (instinctual drives) and the *superego* (societal rules), seeking to satisfy desires in socially acceptable ways through dynamic interaction.
- **Example:** Chester wants to eat a lot of cake but chooses to eat a small portion because he knows it is healthier, balancing instinctual wants with moral/health awareness through the ego.

Gilbert Ryle

- **Core Philosophy:** British philosopher known for critiquing Cartesian dualism, coining the phrase "ghost in the machine." Argued that the self is not a hidden inner entity or ghost, but is defined entirely by observable actions and behaviors in the world. Claimed that speaking of an inner self is a category mistake.
- **Example:** Sarah constantly helps others without expecting anything in return. According to Ryle, her self is not a hidden inner essence, but simply the sum of her helpful behaviors and interactions.

Paul Churchland

- **Core Philosophy:** Canadian philosopher known for studies in neurophilosophy (philosophy of mind). Viewed the self as a direct product of physical brain activity rather than a separate entity, asserting that scientific study of the brain explains self-understanding.
- **Example:** As Benedict practices playing the guitar, his brain physically changes and adapts. Churchland posits that these physical brain processes shape how he views himself and his capabilities.

Maurice Merleau-Ponty

- **Core Philosophy:** French philosopher who rejected dualism, arguing that the self is shaped by the physical body and sensory experiences of the world. Emphasized that the self is inseparable from environmental interactions, developing over time through past experiences and future aspirations.
- **Example:** Joseph expresses identity through dance. His sense of self is not confined to abstract thoughts, but is embodied through the sensory experiences, physical movements, and environmental interactions occurring while dancing.